



S.G. Ganesh

Getting Your First Job

In this month's column, we take a break from discussing technical topics and talk about what most students care about—getting a job.

I get numerous mails from students just out of college looking for help in getting their first job. So I thought it would be useful if I offered some guidance in this column so that it reached a larger number of those just out of college and searching for jobs.

When I was studying in college 10 years back, there were only a handful of engineering colleges in the whole of Tamil Nadu (my native state). Today, there are a few hundred colleges and merely getting a pass mark in +2 is enough to get an engineering seat! The situation is similar in other states as well. Most colleges don't have good placements, and even if they do, it is impossible to get all the students placed. Those who don't get jobs in their city or town, head for cities like Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Pune, Gurgaon, Noida and Chennai, mostly to IT companies. With the large number of job aspirants, it is not at all easy landing your first job, without which life becomes difficult. Some students opt for higher studies while others look for alternative jobs and find them. Many keep searching for jobs, failing which they join courses in less-reputed private institutes and waste their parents' hard-earned money. Most students complain about the policies of IT companies that ask for prior job experience from job applicants. They say that, "If we don't get our first job, how will we get the experience?"

Now, if you look at the IT industry, you'll find a stark contrast: HR managers are interested in recruiting talented freshers because that helps reduce their costs. However, they are unable to find suitable/qualified candidates for most positions! Specifically, at the entry-level, they find that most applicants are unemployable because they lack the necessary (basic or fundamental) skills. My experience with interviewing freshers leads me to completely agree with that view.

Unfortunately, most freshers are weak in the fundamentals of computing, such as data structures, algorithms and C programming (ask them to write a simple string reverse function in C, for example, and you'll understand what I mean). Except for some theoretical knowledge, they lack any practical experience whatsoever on writing code or testing (which gets exposed when they're asked to set a break point in a debugger, for instance). Most freshers also have poor communication skills. Their writing

skills are usually bad; many cannot write even a few sentences without grammatical or spelling mistakes. The average CV lacks substance, and worse, is ridden with mistakes and bad formatting. To cut a long story short, the lack of soft skills and technical skills are the two main reasons that hinder a student from being absorbed into the workforce.

If you're a student searching for or planning to search for a job, don't panic. Getting your first job can be easy – you just have to understand what a prospective employer looks for in candidates and make sure you meet those requirements. To put it succinctly—if you can demonstrate that you're strong in fundamentals, have good communication skills PLUS stand out of the crowd, you're sure to get a job.

So how do you 'stand out from the crowd'? Every interviewer has one question in mind when interviewing you: "Why should I select you and not someone else who is waiting outside to attend this interview for the very same job?" You need to address this question by differentiating yourself from the rest of the crowd. There are many differentiators, like an exceptional academic performance, the relevant certifications, the niche skills that the employer is specifically looking for, or some advanced technical skills that indicate that you're an expert in a particular field. To give you an example, assume you've contributed to an open source project (say Linux) for a period of two years. This prior experience with working on projects reveals many aspects about you—that you're a committed developer (since you've contributed for two years), that you understand how distributed development works (since all major open source projects follow this model of development), that you're strong on fundamentals (how else will you be able to make commits to Linux source code), etc. This is a clear differentiator, and a suitable employer will be more than happy to offer you a job with a good salary package.

There are some common mistakes that freshers make, which I would like to discuss now.

Most students think that having 'good soft skills' means speaking excellent English. That's not at all true. What you need is to just be able to express yourself clearly; further, you need to have good writing skills, a pleasing personality, etc.

Most freshers think that they need to follow the latest technologies to get a good job. That's not true either. For example, cloud computing is popular today, but don't pay a